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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1955-1957

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Place Coverage

South Nyanza District, Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S)

CHANGING PATTERNS OF PREMARITAL SEXUAL BEHAVIOR

The second, and probably modal, type is that of the girl with real ambivalence about engaging in premarital intercourse. She desires it but is careful not to be taken advantage of. Thus she will not meet privately with a boy until after he has bestowed numerous gifts upon her from the market; these may be head scarves, bananas, and candy. She rejects the advances of some boys whom she finds unattractive. Her accessibility for sexual liaisons also depends on her moods and the skill of her would-be seducer. Sometimes she is unapproachable; on other occasions, such as a marriage dance, her resistance may be easily broken down, especially by a dashing young man who serenades her on the guitar. She engages in provocative behavior, mostly of a hostile sort such as sexual joking, but is determined not to be publicly compromised and not to give away her sexual favors until she has received tangible rewards and flattering attention from her prospective lover. With her, resistance in coitus is partly conscious role-playing and partly an expression of real fears and hostility. This type of girl, if her sexual activity is not discovered and does not result in premarital pregnancy, is considered desirable as a wife, for the marriage intermediary (*esigan*) will have no scandal to report to the groom. The prospective husband and his family do not want the intermediary to pry so deeply into the girl's affairs that he reports her casual liaisons; if she has been discreet enough not to acquire a reputation as a "slut," then he ordinarily informs them that she is chaste. There is no inspection of the hymen, for the husband does not desire knowledge of his wife's premarital experience so long as she is considered a proper girl.

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The third type of Gusii girl is the one in whom sex anxiety and hostility toward men outweigh heterosexual desires. Such a girl may acquire a reputation for rejecting sexual advances and eventually be avoided by boys in the marketplace, though her desirability as a wife is in no way diminished. Ordinarily, a girl of this type continues going to the market with the other girls and meets numerous boys who know neither her nor her reputation. Despite

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her fear of sexuality she enjoys the gifts, the flattery, the attention from the boys, and thus tends to exploit her suitors without giving them the sexual satisfaction they desire in exchange. Though she may even refuse sexual overtures at wedding dances and scold the young men who make them, it appears that most girls of this type do occasionally have intercourse before marriage. When they do, their resistance and crying is probably commensurate with their real feelings, and they are more likely to cover their faces during coitus and be 980 overcome with remorse afterwards. It seems likely, though I have no definite evidence on this point, that such girls become the difficult wives who restrict marital sexual activity and who quarrel over it with their husbands.

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